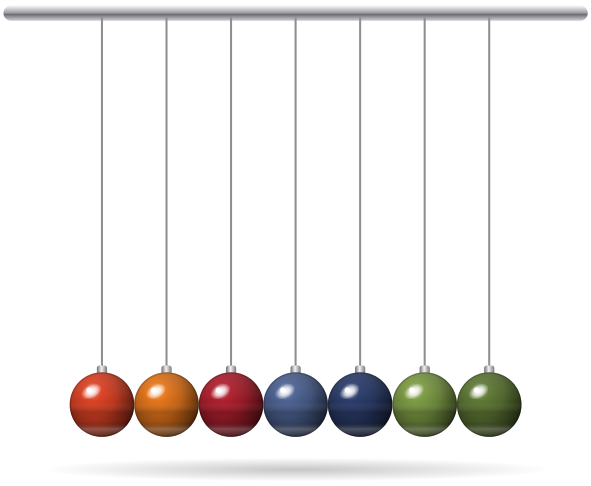
UNION CHURCH
OF MANILA

Coach's Manual

Catalytic Discipleship Lessons

Seven lessons on foundational Christian assurances and practices. Taught one-to-one.



7	5	1½ hr
lessons	core values	max per session

Welcome to UCM's Catalytic Discipleship Lessons.

"Catalytic" means causing a process or event to happen, or increasing the rate at which it happens.

"Catalytic" means causing a process or event to happen or increasing the rate at which it happens. Conducted one-to-one, UCM's Catalytic Discipleship Lessons (CDL) is a seven-lesson set of foundational Christian assurances and practices designed to help activate and accelerate new believers in their spiritual journey.

CDL also aims to equip believers in disciple-making based on Jesus' commission to go and do it. Christians are often content being discipled by osmosis, a gradual, usually unconscious process of absorption. We participate in regular Christian activities like attending church, Bible studies, and seminars, trusting that we will grow passively as disciples. The gradual acquisition of knowledge and experience along the Christian journey is right and good. But there is more to grow and mature into. God calls us to the intentional and deliberate act of making disciples.

This CDL resource is meant to help catalyze UCMers into a renewed approach to the work of the church by increasing their confidence in engaging in disciple-making. How does it work? Outlined by UCM's five core values, each lesson involves a maturing believer and a new believer searching the Scriptures, reflecting on the questions and answers of the faith, and praying. Through the interaction, both individuals may grow deeper in God's Word, prayer, and disciple-making through modeling and practicing in each lesson.

While disciple-making is refreshing, transformative, and sometimes exhilarating, it is rarely convenient and never perfect. The CDL resource was created as a simple tool to help UCM disciple-making become not only accessible but also a lifestyle, enjoying God while fulfilling his great commission.

Are you ready to go? Let's do it!

Centered on the Gospel
Lessons 1 & 2

Called to Renewal
Lessons 3 & 4

Rooted in Scripture
Lesson 5

United in Christ
Lesson 6

Mobilized for Mission
Lesson 7

Contents

Seven lessons. Five core values.

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Mobilized for Mission

The Advancement of God's Kingdom

Ten pointers for a genuine experience.

Congratulations on taking up the opportunity and challenge of making disciples using CDL as your guide. This engagement with another person can produce good fruit that lasts forever.

01

Let the Scriptures always be your authority in answering the questions.

Some learners will need a brief orientation on finding the books, chapters, and verses of the Bible. As appropriate, provide a Bible, a Bible app, or both. For apps, set the version to the ESV (English Standard Version), which UCM has chosen for its discipleship. Point out the NLT (New Living Translation), which learners may like to use to cross-reference.

The biblical texts are included for quick reference (tap any reference on this site). Have learners answer each question based on what the corresponding text actually states, and complete each lesson in advance of the meeting. Keep with the plain meaning and consensus interpretation of the texts and resist going too deep too fast. If a question arises that you cannot answer, say you are unsure and will get back to them. Point out the glossary.

02

Usually go through one CDL a week.

Encourage the learner to undertake the exercises during and after each lesson. Keep sessions to an hour and a half at most. The idea is to finish each lesson wanting more!

03

Avoid preaching!

Use questions to discover what learners understand and to stimulate active participation. In disciple-making, you are also growing in your faith; it happens both ways.

04

Prepare well for each session.

Be familiar with each lesson's key concepts and content. Prayer is essential for preparing hearts for the interaction.

05

Draw out practical implications.

Ask questions like, “How is this relevant to your life right now?”

06

Disciple-making is much more than interacting through CDL.

It implies a life change. This manual is only an initial help. Learners need continual steering in changing their character, ways of thinking, and habits. Pray and ask God to guide you in guiding them.

07

Help learners take up the habit of prayer.

Pray together at the beginning and end of each lesson. It is okay if they do not feel comfortable praying out loud at first; trust they will in due time.

08

Help learners take up the habit of reading the Bible.

Review the prior Scripture memory exercise at the start of each lesson and ask how the Bible reading is going. Be encouraging.

Try	Avoid
“How did your exercises go this past week? What went well? What was difficult?”	“Did you do your homework?” and the like.

09

Be sensitive to what God is doing in the learner’s life.

Take time in each session to answer questions or help with challenges in their personal life. When time runs short, choose the most essential or timely questions to discuss. Skipped questions can be given to learners to search before the next session.

10

Contact UCM for additional Learner’s Manuals.

Write to discipleship@unionchurch.ph

F

Faithful
to Christ’s Commission

A

Available

S

Submissive
to your church oversight

T

Teachable
to receive input and feedback

to the learners growing with you

The Gospel: A Presentation

It is essential for new believers to begin by reviewing the biblical way of having a real relationship with God through Jesus. When a person receives God's good news of salvation, God sees it not as a mere transaction. Through repentance of sin, believing in God, and receiving his offer of salvation through Jesus, God restores our relationship with him and indwells us by the Holy Spirit, who becomes our teacher, comforter, counselor, and helper, calling us into the new life in Christ (John 3:3).

The Bridge Illustration is a classic gospel-centering and sharing tool. It helps us understand the central message of the faith in its simplicity and clarity across generations and cultures. For new believers and others, such simplicity can be the ultimate sophistication.

In intentional disciple-making, such a tool is essential because Christian people are the only Bible or church some people will ever directly encounter (Matthew 28:18; Romans 10:9-10).

Instructions. Internalize the following presentation by reading and rereading it from the perspective of sharing it with another person, either to present it to someone who wants to know or to review it with a new believer embarking on CDL. Follow the bridge as it builds, then respond to the reflection questions at the end.

We matter to God

He made us, and he wants to have a relationship with us. **However**, we have rebelled against God and disobeyed him.

Romans 3:23 says, "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God." Our sin has separated us from God and broken off the relationship.

Sin must be penalized

Furthermore, the sins we have committed must be penalized. The penalty owed is death. Romans 6:23 says, "For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."

Death in the Bible means physical and spiritual death, which means separation from God for eternity in Hell (Matthew 25:41,46).

We can't earn our way back

To varying degrees, most of us are aware of our distance from God. So we start doing all kinds of things, like being charitable, attending church, and making sacrifices to get back to God. These are commendable things, but the Bible clarifies that none can earn us God's forgiveness or re-establish our relationship with him.

Ephesians 2:8-9 says, "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

God built a bridge

It looks pretty hopeless, but the good news is we matter to God. He did for us what we can never do for ourselves. He built a "bridge" by coming to earth as one of us and dying on a cross to pay the death penalty we owed. 1 Peter 3:18: "For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God…"

Jesus is the only bridge back to God. In John 14:6, "Jesus said… 'I am the way, and the truth, and the life, no one comes to the Father except through me.'"

Believe and receive

This is a picture of the central message of the Bible. God wants us to cross over to the other side. But we need more than to know about this or agree with it. We have to act on it.

John 3:16: "For God so loved the world…" and John 1:12: "But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God." Believing and receiving means trusting Jesus Christ alone for your salvation, asking Christ to come and forgive us and lead our lives.

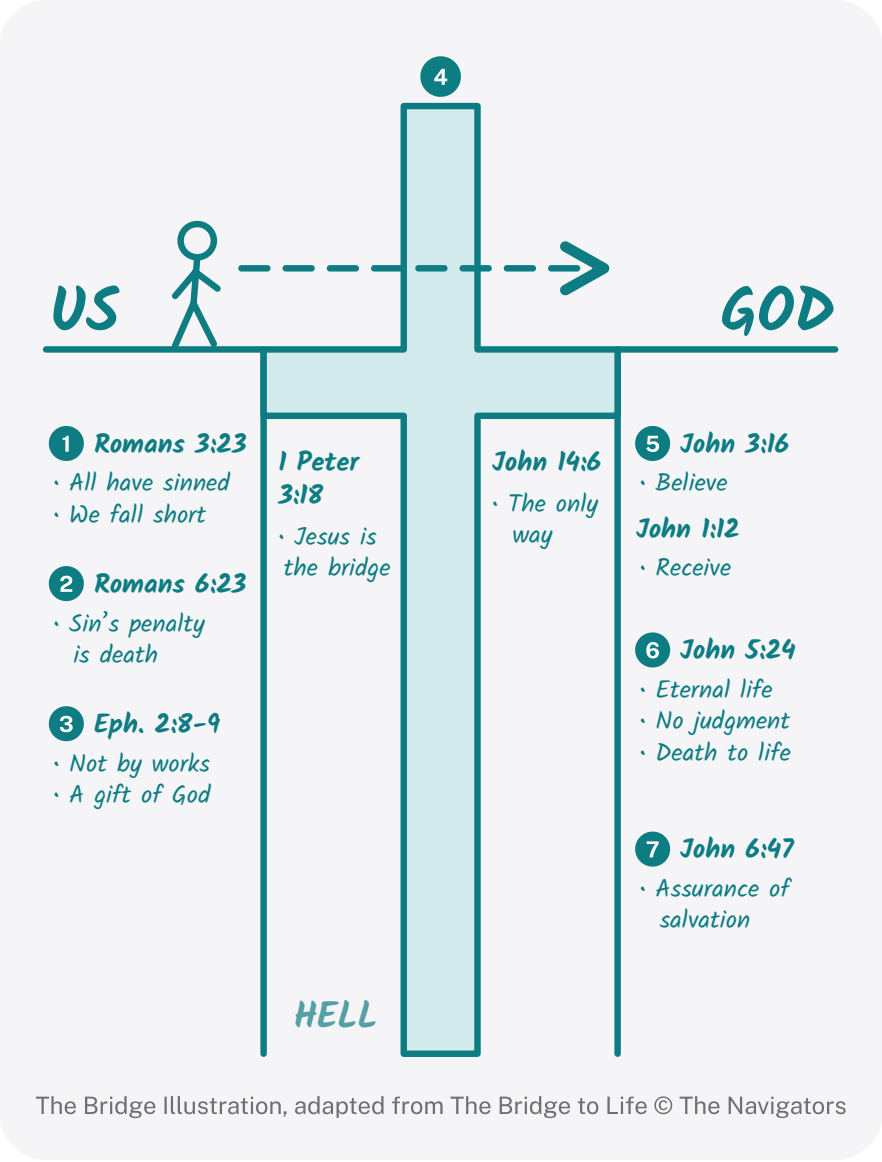
Three promises

When we transfer our complete trust to Jesus alone, he promises to do three things for us. John 5:24: "Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me **(a)** has eternal life. He **(b)** does not come into judgment but **(c)** has passed from death to life."

Assurance

Congratulations! You're a child of God and, through faith, assured of eternal life. When doubts creep in, remember this promise in John 6:47: "Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever believes has eternal life."

Who is speaking here? Jesus. He is God, who died for you so you will have eternal life. He won't lie to you.



The Bridge Illustration, adapted from The Bridge to Life © The Navigators

Does this make sense to you?

"You know, I was *[insert your age]* when I came to this decision in my life. I knew I was a sinner and needed a Savior. I learned that Jesus had paid for my sin on the cross. It was then that I prayed and talked to God, something like this:"

God, I know I am a sinner. CONFESS

But I believe that Jesus died on the cross for my sin. BELIEVE

I now put my trust in Jesus alone for my salvation. TRANSFER TRUST

I ask you to come into my life right now, forgive me, and give me eternal life. RECEIVE

Please lead my life and help me be the person you want me to become. REPENT

Would you like to "cross over the bridge" today by trusting Jesus for your salvation? If yes, we can talk to God by praying the prayer as I did. First, let's clarify what this means:

- ○ Do you know that you are a sinner?
- ○ Do you know that your sin separates you from God?
- ○ Do you believe Jesus paid for our sin in full on the cross?
- ○ Do you now want to turn from your sin and trust in Jesus to save you?

Would you like to pray right now? I can lead us in prayer. Pray after me...

Reflection questions

What was it like for you to go through that presentation? What particularly struck you or stood out to you?

Before the first lesson

Memorize 1 John 5:11-12 and be ready to recite it to your coach at the beginning of CDL 1.

1

Centered on the Gospel

The Assurance of Salvation

In all things, we proclaim and live out the good news of what God has done and is doing in Christ.

Opening question

Can anyone be sure that they are going to Heaven? Briefly explain your answer.

Recite from memory 1 John 5:11-12.

Lesson objective

To give new and spiritually young believers greater confidence in God and the certainty of their eternal life after believing and receiving God's good news: the assurance of salvation. The Scriptures indicate that God wants Christians to understand that they have certainty of eternal life and oneness with God.

Right at the outset of coming to faith in Christ, God's adversary, the evil one, will often cast doubt on the renewing work God has done in you. "Submit yourselves… to God. Resist the devil…" (James 4:7). Your internal thoughts may run like this: *You are not really saved from sin and forgiven by God just by believing and receiving Christ. That is not enough, and you are not enough.*

What will your belief be? Your hope of resisting such spiritual opposition is to resort to God's Word. God's mission is to serve the spiritual needs of his creation on earth, to seek, save, and restore what was lost, ultimately to glorify himself.

Objective Assurance of Salvation

"Objective": not influenced by personal feelings, interpretations, or prejudices; existing independent of an observer or thought.

1. Assurance comes from God through his Word.

Read aloud 1 John 5:11-12. Based on "the testimony," God's written Word, you can be convinced you have Jesus Christ, the Word of God, and with him eternal life. Spiritual opposition may recur, but now you can meet it with God's Word.

According to John's testimony in 1 John 5:11-13,

Who gives eternal life?
God

Where is eternal life found?
in the Son (Jesus Christ)

Who has eternal life?
whoever has the Son

Who does not have this life?
whoever does not have the Son

What's the meaning of "having the Son"?
believing in the name of the Son of God

Can you now put this assurance in your own words?
God says that I could be sure of eternal life because I have accepted his Son Jesus Christ in my life by believing in him.

2. Assurance comes from what God has done and is doing for us, that which we cannot do.

Read Titus 3:4-7. What is the basis of our salvation?
goodness and loving kindness of God; his mercy; the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit

Would we be sure of our salvation if it is based on what we could do? Explain.
No. If my assurance of salvation is based on the righteous things I do, I will never be sure since I do unrighteous acts as well. It is like making an omelet from a combination of good and rotten eggs; it will never be acceptable.

3. Assurance comes from faith in God's promises.

Assurance springs not from the power of positive thinking but from the power of God's good news, the gospel. Assurance of salvation is primarily grounded in God's promises. In Romans 4:21, faith takes God at his word.

State Romans 8:38-39 in your words:

Nothing and no one, no situation or experience in the past, present, and future can separate me from God's love in Christ Jesus.

Trust is the basis of any close relationship. Our trust will be strengthened by getting to know who God truly is and seeking to commune with him daily through prayer and his Word.

Some people may not feel fully forgiven, or feel unworthy or unlovable, perhaps believing their sins were too great, feeling ashamed, or discovering they cannot lead a sinless life even with the Holy Spirit. Do not be discouraged! The gospel is not about "sin management" but receiving and pursuing a real relationship with God in Jesus Christ. We have been given the Spirit to strengthen us when we are weak (2 Corinthians 12:9-10).

Victorious Christian living is covered in Lesson 3; the trustworthiness of God's Word in Lesson 5.

Subjective Assurance of Salvation

"Subjective": belonging to the thinking subject rather than to the object of thought; the result of personal feelings, tastes, or opinions.

1. Assurance also comes from the Holy Spirit, who testifies directly to the believer's spirit that we are children of God.

Read Romans 8:15-16. What does the Spirit enable the believer to do?

The Holy Spirit enables the believer to accept that s/he has been adopted by God.

What does the Spirit do with our spirit?

The Holy Spirit assures us that we are children of God.

Read John 7:38-39. How can you know you have the Holy Spirit?

if we believe in Christ Jesus

More on the nature and work of the Spirit is covered in Lesson 4.

2. Assurance comes from the evidence of a transformed life.

The transformed life can function as a sign and subjective form of assurance.

Read 1 John 2:3. What testifies that one knows one belongs to God?

when one keeps Christ's commandments

Read 1 John 3:14. What evidence could one show that s/he has passed from death to life?

S/he loves the children of God (brothers and sisters in Christ).

Read 2 Peter 1:3-11. How does a believer confirm or make sure of their salvation?

S/he experiences development of Godly qualities in their life.

Dealing with doubt in your new relationship with Christ

Even though feelings are important, your relationship with Christ is based on facts, not on feelings that can change daily. Doubt, questions, and varying emotions are common parts of everyone's life, but they are unreliable gauges of anyone's relationship with Christ. The Christian lives by faith in the trustworthiness of God and his Word.



This train diagram illustrates the relationship between **fact** (God and his Word), **faith** (your trust in God and his Word), and **feeling**. The train will run with or without the caboose. However, it would be useless to attempt to pull the train by the caboose. In the same way, Christians do not depend on feelings. The more you learn of his Word, the more you will be able to answer any doubts with solid facts, and your feelings will increasingly respond to the truth of God's Word rather than your circumstances.

Before the next lesson

Memorize 1 John 1:9 and be ready to recite it to your coach at the beginning of CDL 2.

Read **John 1–7** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

1 John 5:11-12

[11] And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. [12] Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life.

1 John 5:11-13

[11] And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. [12] Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. [13] I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life.

Titus 3:4-7

[4] But when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared, [5] he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, [6] whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, [7] so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life.

Romans 4:21

[21] fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised.

Romans 8:38-39

[38] For I am sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, [39] nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.

2 Corinthians 12:9-10

[9] But he said to me, “My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.” Therefore I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me. [10] For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong.

Romans 8:15-16

[15] For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, “Abba! Father!” [16] The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God,

John 7:38-39

[38] Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, ‘Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.’” [39] Now this he said about the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were to receive, for as yet the Spirit had not been given, because Jesus was not yet glorified.

1 John 2:3

[3] …we know that we have come to know him, if we keep his commandments.

1 John 3:14

[14] We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers. Whoever does not love abides in death.

2 Peter 1:3-11

[3] His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, [4] by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire. [5] For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, [6] and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, [7] and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. [8] For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. [9] For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted that he is blind, having forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. [10] Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall. [11] For in this way there will be richly provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

1 John 1:9

9 If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive
us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

2

Centered on the Gospel

The Assurance of Forgiveness

In all things, we proclaim and live out the good news of what God has done and is doing in Christ.

Opening question

Describe a time when you "missed the mark," failed, or fell short on something you wanted to do.

Recite 1 John 1:9.

Lesson objective

This lesson helps increase our trust in God and the certainty of forgiveness in receiving Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord.

Having a real relationship with Jesus means we open our lives to be completely transparent and honest before him. When we falter, we can admit our shortcomings to God, and his forgiveness is guaranteed to us. When we begin a relationship with Jesus, we are given a new heart to want to live pleasingly to God (Ezekiel 36:26). But while we still live in this fallen world, there will be times when we fall short and give way to sin, and the evil one may accuse us in our thoughts: *Aren't you supposed to be a Christian? Christians don't do those things. Just give up on this whole thing.*

Sin & its effect

1. What is sin in your own words?

Anything that falls short of conformity to God's standard and will

2. Read Psalm 51:1,2,12. What happens when we sin? What do we lose?

We lose the joy of our salvation.

We do **not** lose our salvation but cannot enjoy it when sinning.

Read Ephesians 4:29-31. What happens with the Spirit of God when we sin?
We grieve the Holy Spirit of God.

Read 1 John 1:8-9. What should we do when we fall short and sin?
We should confess our sin.

To confess a sin means acknowledging, uncovering, and calling it exactly what God calls it. When we honestly confess a sin before God, we are willing to forsake the sin by turning away from it.

What two things does God promise to do when we confess our sins to him?
He forgives us our sins and cleanses us from all unrighteousness.

What is your reflection on this section?

Biblical & true forgiveness

3. What does biblical, true forgiveness mean?

A **Holding no fault or offense against a person.** What does Psalm 103:10 say about God?
God does not deal with us according to our sins nor repay us according to our iniquities; he does not give us the punishment we deserve.

B **Having no animosity toward a person** (ill will, hatred, resentment, hostility). Read Romans 5:6-8. What does God do for us?
He showed his love to us when we were hopelessly trapped in our sins and disobedience. Christ died for us.

C **Being able to leave the fault or offense right where it is, in the past, and move on.** What does Psalm 103:12 say about God?
He removed our transgressions from us.

How is God's forgiveness described in Hebrews 8:12?
He will no longer remember our sins.

Biblical illustration

Read Luke 15:11-32: the Parable of the Prodigal Son. We see the loving kindness of the father that moved him to forgiveness. We also see the unforgiving heart of the older brother, which reminds us of our appropriate response to another's offense: "forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors" (Matthew 6:12). What is your response to the story?

A.C.T.S. praying

Based on elements of the prayer Jesus taught his disciples.

Confessing our sins before God and receiving his forgiveness is something we can do as part of our regular prayer life. Each time we meet with God, we can ask him to search our hearts and reveal any sin we can confess so that there will be no barrier between us (Psalm 139:23-24). Here is a prayer model that incorporates confession into time spent with God:

A **Adoration.** Praise God for who he is!

C **Confession.** Ask God to show you sins you may not even realize, and receive forgiveness.

T **Thanksgiving.** Thank God for everything he has done, is doing, and will do in your life.

S **Supplication.** Present your requests to God.

Begin praying. As you do, know that God, our loving Father, is delighting in you! What is your reflection on this section?

Before the next lesson

Practice A.C.T.S. and reflect further on how you came to place your faith in Christ and how that has changed your life. Memorize 1 Corinthians 10:13. Come ready to share your faith story, how you became a Christian, briefly with your coach at the beginning of CDL 3.

Read **John 8–14** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

1 John 1:9

9 If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

Ezekiel 36:26

26 And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.

Psalm 51:1,2,12

1 Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions. 2 Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin! 12 Restore to me the joy of your salvation, and uphold me with a willing spirit.

Ephesians 4:29-31

29 Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for building up, as fits the occasion, that it may give grace to those who hear. 30 And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption. 31 Let all bitterness and wrath and anger and clamor and slander be put away from you, along with all malice.

1 John 1:8-9

8 If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. 9 If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

Psalm 103:10

10 He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities.

Romans 5:6-8

6 For while we were still weak, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly. 7 For one will scarcely die for a righteous person — though perhaps for a good person one would dare even to die — 8 but God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.

Psalm 103:12

12 as far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us.

Hebrews 8:12

12 For I will be merciful toward their iniquities, and I will remember their sins no more."

Psalm 139:23-24

23 Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! 24 And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting!

1 Corinthians 10:13

13 No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability, but with the temptation he will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it.

3

Called to Renewal

The Assurance of Victorious Christian Living

We seek to cultivate Spirit-empowered restoration and transformation in our communities.

Opening question

Describe a time you won something. It can be anything. What did achieving victory feel like?

Share your faith story briefly and recite 1 Corinthians 10:13.

Lesson objective

This lesson helps raise awareness of the privilege of enjoying God's salvation and forgiveness through our daily decision to walk with God. Spiritual growth happens when we pursue God across the "hills and valleys" of life. The authentic Christian life is faithful, makes spiritual progress, and perseveres.

> "And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him."
>
> Hebrews 11:6

The overflowing effects of our faith in Jesus enable us to walk victoriously in our Christian lives.

God's promise of victory

1. Read 1 Corinthians 15:57. What does God give us?

He gives us victory through Jesus Christ.

2. Read 1 John 5:4-5. What does it mean that he gives us victory versus striving for it?

Believing that Jesus is the Son of God, fully trusting him (faith), gives us victory

3. Read 1 Corinthians 10:13.

What does victory mean in this context?

victory over temptation and sin

What common experience do we have?

temptation

"Temptation" depicts the moment when we feel seized and squeezed by external or internal forces designed to bring us down.

What does God promise concerning temptation?

He will provide the way of escape that we may be able to endure it.



The **Plimsoll line** is a reference mark on a ship's hull that indicates the maximum depth to which the vessel may be safely immersed when loaded with cargo. "God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability..." (1 Corinthians 10:13).

God will always provide a way to escape whatever temptation stands before us. If we look for a way to avoid whatever sin compels us, God promises we will find it.

4. How can we live victoriously?

Read John 16:33:

accept the fact that Christ has already won for us the victory

Read 1 John 5:5:

believe that Jesus is the Son of God

Keys to victorious Christian living

Read
Ephesians 4:17-24.

1. Recognize the kind of world we are living in.

How did Paul describe the not-yet believers (verses 18–19)?
Paul called them Gentiles who live in the futility (pointlessness or uselessness) of their minds.

Here we find the not-yet believers' worldview, state of mind, and way of life. Enumerate the characteristics.
darkened in understanding; alienated from the life of God; ignorant due to hardness of heart; callous; given up to sensuality; greedy to practice every kind of impurity

Have you observed any similarities in your own life? Give a specific example.

2. Acknowledge that we are prone to follow the dictates of this world.

What is Paul's exhortation to the believers (verse 17)?
They should no longer live as the Gentiles do.

Though we are no longer of this world, we are still in this world, which means we can still be affected by it in how we think and act. Paul's exhortation and testimony are illuminating: "...let anyone who thinks he stands take heed lest he fall" (1 Corinthians 10:12); also see Romans 7:18b-19, which invites us to live with caution, but we need not live in fear. We can trust the Holy Spirit to guide us into all truth as he promises (John 16:13).

In what ways do we allow "the world" and its way of life to sway us to think and live like we are still of the world? Example?
by allowing our lives to be saturated by the things and ideals of the world instead of knowing and practicing what the Bible exhorts us to have and do

3. Subscribe to God's way and cooperate with him.

What are we to put off (Ephesians 4:22-23)?

our old self, our former manner of life that was dictated by corrupt and deceitful desires

What are we to put on (Ephesians 4:24)?

the new self, characterized by righteousness and holiness

We "put on" when we received Christ as Savior and Lord. We are given the "position" as children of God, and this never changes. But "putting off" is a repeating experience. It relates to our "state," our daily observance as followers of Christ, and it happens not by our strength or striving (2 Corinthians 12:9-10). When we accept this weakness, he gives us the favor and strength to make choices in line with his truth: "...for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure" (Philippians 2:13).

How we subscribe to God's ways of life

1. **We discard our old habits,** identifying and consciously letting go of sinful patterns from our former way of life.
2. **We clothe ourselves in Christ,** embracing the righteousness and holiness of Christ as our new identity.
3. **We renew our minds** by regularly meditating on God's Word and praying to allow God to transform our thinking into his likeness.
4. **We give God full access to our hearts.** Jesus says, "For out of the heart come evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, theft, false witness, slander" (Matthew 15:19). We need Jesus to touch and transform our hearts. We can give him total access by inviting him in and asking him to show us what needs his healing (John 15:4).

Before the next lesson

Practice A.C.T.S. and memorize John 14:26; be ready to recite it to your coach at the beginning of CDL 4.

Read **John 15–21** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

1 Corinthians 10:13

13 No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability, but with the temptation he will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it.

Hebrews 11:6

6 And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him.

1 Corinthians 15:57

57 But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 John 5:4-5

4 For everyone who has been born of God overcomes the world. And this is the victory that has overcome the world—our faith. 5 Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God?

John 16:33

33 I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world."

1 John 5:5

5 Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God?

Ephesians 4:17-24

17 Now this I say and testify in the Lord, that you must no longer walk as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their minds. 18 They are darkened in their understanding, alienated from the life of God because of the ignorance that is in them, due to their hardness of heart. 19 They have become callous and have given themselves up to sensuality, greedy to practice every kind of impurity.
20 But that is not the way you learned Christ!—
21 assuming that you have heard about him and were taught in him, as the truth is in Jesus, 22 to put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful desires, 23 and to be renewed in the spirit of your minds, 24 and to put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.

Romans 7:18b-19

18 ...For I have the desire to do what is right, but not the ability to carry it out. 19 For I do not do the good I want, but the evil I do not want is what I keep doing.

John 16:13

13 When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth, for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will declare to you the things that are to come.

2 Corinthians 12:9-10

9 But he said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness." Therefore I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me. 10 For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong.

Philippians 2:13

13 for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

Matthew 15:19

19 For out of the heart come evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, theft, false witness, slander.

John 15:4

4 Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in me.

John 14:26

26 But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you.

4

Called to Renewal

The Person and Work of the Holy Spirit

We seek to cultivate Spirit-empowered restoration and transformation in our communities.

Opening question

What significant voices have you listened to in your life thus far (parents, pastors, spouse, biblical authors, favorite preachers and teachers, friends, etc.)?

Recite John 14:26.

Lesson objective

This lesson helps us recognize that with the good news, we have received the Holy Spirit, who continuously renews, strengthens, and guides us in our lives of faith. We have the Holy Spirit in our trials and to minister to others.

The person of the Holy Spirit

1. What does the Spirit possess that shows he is a person?

Ephesians 4:30	*he has emotion: we could grieve him*
John 14:26	*he demonstrates intelligence as he teaches and guides believers*
1 Corinthians 12:11	*he decides based on his intent, "as he wills"*

The Holy Spirit possesses emotion, intellect, and will, the three fundamental attributes of a person. That means we refer to him as "he" rather than "it."

2. What attributes or traits of deity does the Spirit possess?

Psalm 139:7	everything is in his immediate presence; no one, nothing escapes his presence
Zechariah 4:6	power belongs to him
1 Corinthians 2:10-11, Psalm 139:2-6	he is all-knowing

Based on these passages, who then is the Holy Spirit?

The Holy Spirit possesses characteristics that only God possesses; he is therefore God.

Now that we have learned about the Holy Spirit's nature, let us turn to his work.

The work of the Holy Spirit

1. What works does the Spirit do that only God can do?

Job 33:4	he is our Creator, he is the Giver of life
Titus 3:5	he saves us
2 Thessalonians 2:13-14	he sanctifies us

2. What is the relationship of the Holy Spirit with believers?

A He brings conviction to the not-yet believer and causes them to see the gospel's truth. Read John 16:8-11.

B He indwells the believer permanently. Read 1 Corinthians 6:19 and 1 Corinthians 6:20.

C He seals the believer. Read 2 Corinthians 1:22, Ephesians 1:13, and Ephesians 4:30.

D He sovereignly bestows spiritual gifts or abilities to every believer to build up the church and be the church to a lost and broken world. Read 1 Corinthians 12:4-11.

3. What else does the Holy Spirit do?

A Helps us to know and carry out God's will (Ezekiel 36:26-27)

B Makes God's presence evident in us (John 7:38-39, John 14:23)

C Serves as Help that will remain with us forever (John 14:16)

D Reminds us of Jesus' words (John 14:26)

E Offers guidance into the truth and tells us what is ahead (John 16:13)

F Gives us power beyond our strength (Luke 24:49)

G Enables us to be witnesses carrying out Jesus' ministry of healing the sick and setting the captives free (Acts 1:8)

H Fills us with the life of Christ (Romans 8:11)

I Reminds us of our identity as God's sons and daughters (Romans 8:14-15)

J Helps us to pray and make intercession (Romans 8:26)

K Helps us live freely, animated, and motivated by God's Spirit instead of

Before the next lesson

Practice A.C.T.S. and memorize 2 Timothy 3:16; be ready to recite it to your coach at the beginning of CDL 5.

Read **Acts 8–12** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

John 14:26

[26] But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you.

Ephesians 4:30

[30] And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.

1 Corinthians 12:11

[11] All these [gifts] are empowered by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills.

Psalm 139:7

[7] Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence?

Zechariah 4:6

[6] Then he said to me, "This is the word of the LORD to Zerubbabel: Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.

1 Corinthians 2:10-11

[10] these things God has revealed to us through the Spirit. For the Spirit searches everything, even the depths of God. [11] For who knows a person's thoughts except the spirit of that person, which is in him? So also no one comprehends the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God.

Psalm 139:2-6

[2] You know when I sit down and when I rise up; you discern my thoughts from afar. [3] You search out my path and my lying down and are acquainted with all my ways. [4] Even before a word is on my tongue, behold, O LORD, you know it altogether. [5] You hem me in, behind and before, and lay your hand upon me. [6] Such knowledge is too wonderful for me; it is high; I cannot attain it.

Job 33:4

[4] The Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life.

Titus 3:5

[5] he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit,

2 Thessalonians 2:13-14

[13] But we ought always to give thanks to God for you, brothers beloved by the Lord, because God chose you as the first to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth. [14] To this he called you through our gospel, so that you may obtain the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ.

John 16:8-11

[8] And when he comes, he will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment: [9] concerning sin, because they do not believe in me; [10] concerning righteousness, because I go to the Father, and you will see me no longer; [11] concerning judgment, because the ruler of this world is judged.

1 Corinthians 6:19

[19] Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God? You are not your own,

1 Corinthians 6:20

[20] for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body.

2 Corinthians 1:22

[22] and who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.

Ephesians 1:13

[13] In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit,

1 Corinthians 12:4-11

4 Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit;
5 and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord;
6 and there are varieties of activities, but it is the same God who empowers them all in everyone. 7 To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good. 8 For to one is given through the Spirit the utterance of wisdom, and to another the utterance of knowledge according to the same Spirit, 9 to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healing by the one Spirit, 10 to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another the ability to distinguish between spirits, to another various kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues. 11 All these are empowered by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills.

Ezekiel 36:26-27

26 And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. 27 And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules.

John 7:38-39

38 Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, 'Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.'" 39 Now this he said about the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were to receive, for as yet the Spirit had not been given, because Jesus was not yet glorified.

John 14:23

23 Jesus answered him, "If anyone loves me, he will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come to him and make our home with him.

John 14:16

16 And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever,

John 16:13

13 When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth, for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will declare to you the things that are to come.

Luke 24:49

49 And behold, I am sending the promise of my Father upon you. But stay in the city until you are clothed with power from on high."

Acts 1:8

8 But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

Romans 8:11

11 If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through his Spirit who dwells in you.

Romans 8:14-15

14 For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. 15 For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, "Abba! Father!"

Romans 8:26

26 Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words.

Galatians 5:16-17

16 But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. 17 For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do.

Galatians 5:22-24

22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law. 24 And those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.

2 Corinthians 3:18

18 And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit.

2 Timothy 3:16

16 All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness,

5

Rooted in Scripture

The Trustworthiness of the Bible

We devote ourselves to understanding, obeying, and delighting in God's Word.

Opening question

"All sources of information about God are of equal authority and significance." True or false?

Recite from memory
2 Timothy 3:16.

Lesson objective

This lesson helps us further comprehend the gospel by increasing our reliance upon God's Word as the ultimate authority and standard of faith and practice.

The source of the Bible

What phrase describes Scripture as being from God?
breathed out by God

What does this mean to you?
The Bible is from God and therefore I should consider it my ultimate authority for my faith and Christian living.

Read 2 Peter 1:20-21. Where do prophecies of Scripture come from?
No prophecy was ever produced by the will of man; the Holy Spirit "carried along" those who spoke prophecy.

What phrases are repeated in these similar verses: Deuteronomy 5:27; Isaiah 40:1; Isaiah 57:21; Jeremiah 42:20; Ezekiel 34:31; Psalm 75:2?
God says, God speaks, God declares

"All Scripture is breathed out by God" (2 Timothy 3:16) and "...as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Peter 1:21) mean that God inspired and superintended the human authors, so they wrote what he intended. Therefore, the Bible we have is true, accurate, and reliable. Are we supposed to take the Bible's word for it about its own nature and character? Yes. Personal experience and testimonies of believers point to the fact that once a person receives Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord, there

is an unmistakable openness and receptivity to the Bible, primarily caused by the indwelling presence of the Holy Spirit, who convicts and teaches us.

The benefits of the Word

1. Explore some of the significant benefits of the Bible in our lives.

Romans 10:17	*Faith comes from hearing the word of Christ.*
Ephesians 6:17	*The Word of God is our sword, the only offensive weapon in the armor of God.*
2 Timothy 3:17	*makes us complete and equips us for every good work*

The Bible tells us when we are off the right track, directs us back to the right track, and enables us to stay on it.

2. Analogies for the Word: what terms and descriptions are used for God's Word in Psalm 19:7-10?

law; perfect; testimony; sure; precepts; right; commandment; pure; fear; clean; rules; true

reviving the soul; making wise the simple; rejoicing the heart; enlightening the eyes; enduring forever; righteous altogether; desirous; sweet

3. Taking in God's Word: how do we take in the Word?

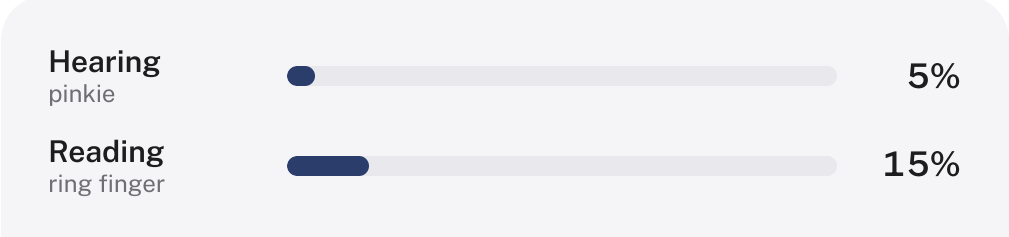
Jeremiah 10:1	*Hear*
Deuteronomy 17:18-19	*Read*
2 Timothy 2:15	*Study*
Psalm 119:11	*Memorize (store up)*
Joshua 1:8	*Meditate*

What is the intent of hearing, reading, and meditating on the Word according to Psalm 1:2; Luke 11:28; Matthew 7:24; John 13:17; James 1:22?

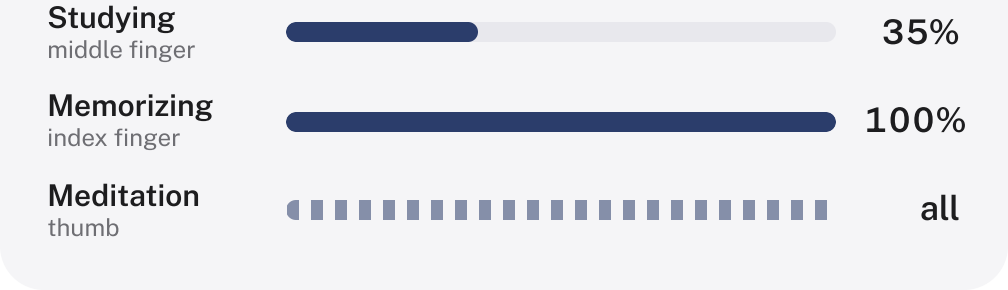
Apply to one's life what the Word says.

The Hand Illustration

by The Navigators.
How much we retain



by each way of taking in the Word.



1. Hearing the Word from pastors and teachers provides fresh insight into the Scriptures. The weakest finger represents hearing, because we retain only 5 percent of what we hear. Romans 10:17

2. Reading gives us an overview of the Bible and is the foundation of a regular quiet time. We generally retain 15 percent of what we read. Revelation 1:3

3. Studying the Scriptures deepens our conviction. It requires greater time and effort but results in increased Bible knowledge. Most people retain 35 percent of what they study. Acts 17:11

4. Memorizing the Word enables us to use the Sword of the Spirit to overcome temptations and to have verses ready for ministering to others. The index finger, our strongest, represents memorization. We remember 100 percent of what we memorize if we consistently review it. Psalm 119:9-11

5. Meditation is the inward process that accompanies each of the other four. Only the thumb can touch all the other fingers. By meditating on God's Word as we hear, read, study, and memorize, we discover its transforming power at work in us. Psalm 1:2-3

Interacting with God's Word

The S.O.A.P.S. Bible reading method

As followers of Jesus, we can commune with God daily through his Word. A fair guideline is to read five or more chapters each week. But how do I apply what I learn? Keeping a journal using the S.O.A.P.S. method can help you understand, observe, and delight in God through his Word.

S **Scripture.** Write out one or more verses that are particularly meaningful to you today.

O **Observation.** Rewrite those verses or key points in your own words to better understand.

An example

S "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways," declares the LORD. "For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts" (Isaiah 55:8-9).

O As a human being, I am limited in what I know and in how to do what I know. God is not limited in

A	**Application.** Consider what God might be communicating to you and how you might observe and apply it.	any way. He sees and knows everything; nothing is impossible for him. **A** Since God knows everything and his ways are best, rather than relying on my way of doing things, the better way is to follow him.
P	**Prayer.** Write a prayer expressing your honor, love, and thanksgiving to God, and how you plan to incorporate what you received.	**P** God, I don't know how to live a good life that pleases you and helps others. My ways can lead to mistakes, and my thoughts can lead to hurt. Please teach me your ways and your thoughts instead. Holy Spirit, please help me.
S	**Sharing.** Ask God if there is anyone he wants you to share with about what you learned.	**S** I will share these verses and this application with my friend, Steve, who is going through a difficult time and might need direction for essential decisions he's facing.

The Scriptures are not meant to serve as a static "letter of the law" like the Pharisees used to observe his commands. The Bible is living and active (Hebrews 4:12), enabling us to encounter the fellowship of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. We are called to understand, observe, and delight in God's Word, not only for head knowledge but as God's Word that meets us wholeheartedly in growing our relationship with him and others (Luke 24:32).

Exercise

Choose one to three verses from Psalm 116:1-7 and create your S.O.A.P.S.

Before the next lesson

Practice A.C.T.S. and memorize Hebrews 10:24-25; be ready to recite it to your coach at the beginning of CDL 6.

Read **Ephesians 1–6** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

2 Timothy 3:16

16 All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable
for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training
in righteousness,

2 Peter 1:20-21

20 knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of
Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation.
21 For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of
man, but men spoke from God as they were carried
along by the Holy Spirit.

Deuteronomy 5:27

27 Go near and hear all that the LORD our God will say,
and speak to us all that the LORD our God will speak to
you, and we will hear and do it.'

Isaiah 40:1

1 Comfort, comfort my people, says your God.

Isaiah 57:21

21 There is no peace," says my God, "for the wicked."

Jeremiah 42:20

20 that you have gone astray at the cost of your lives.
For you sent me to the LORD your God, saying, 'Pray for
us to the LORD our God, and whatever the LORD our
God says, declare to us and we will do it.'

Ezekiel 34:31

31 And you are my sheep, human sheep of my pasture,
and I am your God, declares the Lord GOD."

Psalm 75:2

2 "At the set time that I appoint I will judge with equity.

Romans 10:17

17 So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through
the word of Christ.

Ephesians 6:17

17 and take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of
the Spirit, which is the word of God,

2 Timothy 3:17

17 that the man of God may be complete, equipped for
every good work.

Psalm 19:7-10

7 The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the
testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple;
8 the precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the
heart; the commandment of the LORD is pure,
enlightening the eyes; 9 the fear of the LORD is clean,
enduring forever; the rules of the LORD are true, and
righteous altogether. 10 More to be desired are they
than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than
honey and drippings of the honeycomb.

Jeremiah 10:1

1 Hear the word that the LORD speaks to you, O house
of Israel.

Deuteronomy 17:18-19

18 "And when he sits on the throne of his kingdom, he
shall write for himself in a book a copy of this law,
approved by the Levitical priests. 19 And it shall be with
him, and he shall read in it all the days of his life, that
he may learn to fear the LORD his God by keeping all
the words of this law and these statutes, and doing
them,

2 Timothy 2:15

15 Do your best to present yourself to God as one
approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed,
rightly handling the word of truth.

Psalm 119:11

11 I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might
not sin against you.

Joshua 1:8

8 This Book of the Law shall not depart from your
mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, so
that you may be careful to do according to all that is
written in it. For then you will make your way
prosperous, and then you will have good success.

Psalm 1:2

2 but his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his
law he meditates day and night.

Luke 11:28

28 But he said, "Blessed rather are those who hear the
word of God and keep it!"

Matthew 7:24

24 “Everyone then who hears these words of mine and
does them will be like a wise man who built his house
on the rock.

John 13:17

17 If you know these things, blessed are you if you do
them.

James 1:22

22 But be doers of the word, and not hearers only,
deceiving yourselves.

Revelation 1:3

3 Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this
prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who
keep what is written in it, for the time is near.

Acts 17:11

11 Now these Jews were more noble than those in
Thessalonica; they received the word with all
eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if
these things were so.

Psalm 119:9-11

9 How can a young man keep his way pure? By
guarding it according to your word. 10 With my whole
heart I seek you; let me not wander from your
commandments! 11 I have stored up your word in my
heart, that I might not sin against you.

Psalm 1:2-3

2 but his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his
law he meditates day and night. 3 He is like a tree
planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its
season, and its leaf does not wither. In all that he does,
he prospers.

Hebrews 4:12

12 For the word of God is living and active, sharper than
any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul
and of spirit, of joints and of marrow, and discerning
the thoughts and intentions of the heart.

Luke 24:32

32 They said to each other, “Did not our hearts burn
within us while he talked to us on the road, while he
opened to us the Scriptures?”

Psalm 116:1-7

1 I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice and
my pleas for mercy. 2 Because he inclined his ear to me,
therefore I will call on him as long as I live. 3 The snares
of death encompassed me; the pangs of Sheol laid hold
on me; I suffered distress and anguish. 4 Then I called
on the name of the LORD: “O LORD, I pray, deliver my
soul!” 5 Gracious is the LORD, and righteous; our God is
merciful. 6 The LORD preserves the simple; when I was
brought low, he saved me. 7 Return, O my soul, to your
rest; for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.

Hebrews 10:24-25

24 And let us consider how to stir up one another to love
and good works, 25 not neglecting to meet together, as
is the habit of some, but encouraging one another, and
all the more as you see the Day drawing near.

6

United in Christ

The Fellowship of Believers

We are an international community from diverse backgrounds, cultures, and denominations bound together by our common commitment to exalt the person and work of Jesus Christ.

Opening question

When did you draw strength or joy from being with a group?

Recite Hebrews 10:24-25.

Lesson objective

This lesson helps raise awareness that embracing what Jesus did for us through the gospel immediately connects us to others like nothing else. We have a disposition for worshiping God and a vision for it (Revelation 4:11). We never have to do faith-life alone but are united through a diverse people where there is refinement and encouragement in growing together (John 17:23; Ephesians 1:10).

The term “Church” is the body of believers we are joined with the moment we come to faith in Christ. What are the features of this living group of people?

The nature of the Church

1. The Church is invisible.

The Church has been the community of all true believers since God first poured out his Spirit on them. It is invisible in its true reality as the fellowship of all believers since that time; we cannot see it as God sees it.

How is the church described in Hebrews 12:1,23?

a great cloud of witnesses; the assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven... the spirits of the righteous made perfect

2. The Church is visible and universal (as Christians on earth see it).

The visible Church is the group of people who come together each Sunday to worship, profess faith in Christ, and live and act as a community of believers. The Bible also encourages us to come together as often as we can. One way to do this at UCM is to join one of the church's **Small Groups**: close fellowship times including food together, sharing testimonies, praising God, helping each other out, praying, and inviting others to join in. These groups are one of the main avenues through which we grow and mature in our faith.

The invisible Church joins the visible, universal Church in worship and is composed of all believers throughout the entire world at a given time (1 Corinthians 12:13; Ephesians 3:14-15).

3. The Church is local. Locate the church in the following verses:

Romans 16:5	"church in their house"
1 Corinthians 16:19	churches of Asia (modern-day Turkey)
1 Corinthians 1:2	in Corinth (south-central Greece), in every place
2 Corinthians 1:1	in Corinth; in Achaia (western Greece)
1 Thessalonians 1:1	Thessalonica (northern Greece)
Acts 9:31	Judea, Galilee, Samaria (Israel)

4. The importance of the Church for believers.

Read Acts 2:42. What was the focus of the early believers?

Apostles' teaching (the Word); fellowship; breaking of bread; prayers

Read Ephesians 2:19. How are the believers described?

no longer strangers and aliens; fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God

Read Hebrews 10:24-25. What is the exhortation to the believers, and what is its purpose?

do not neglect meeting together (face to face) so that we would be able to stir up (encourage) one another to love and good works

The local church is of utmost importance because in and through this local fellowship of diverse people, refinement and encouragement in growing together happen. We were never meant to do faith-life alone. The phrase "one another" occurs 100 times in the New Testament; approximately 59 of those are specific commands teaching us how (and how not) to relate to one another.

What will you do to begin the habit of meeting together with other believers? Ask your coach how s/he practices faith with others.

Sharing the fellowship

Because Christians are the only Bible or church some people will ever really encounter, we want to be prepared to share with anyone who asks, in addition to our faith story, the reason for our hope, with gentleness and respect (1 Peter 3:15). God has already given us relationships where we may share: family, friends, neighbors, co-workers, and classmates.

Three kinds of people we will meet

1	Open to us as messengers and open to our message
2	Open to us as messengers but not open to our message
3	Not open to us as messengers and not open to our message

Take five minutes to list people in your sphere of influence who are not yet part of the fellowship of believers, people you know how to contact and have

an ongoing connection with. Prioritize those who are open to us and our message.

Pray for these people regularly so that you can share the reason for your hope and the fellowship God has given you. Remember your gospel-sharing tool, the Bridge Illustration.

Before the next lesson

Practice A.C.T.S. and memorize Matthew 6:33.

Read **Acts 1–7** in the next seven days.

Scripture for this lesson

Hebrews 10:24-25

[24] And let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works, [25] not neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging one another, and all the more as you see the Day drawing near.

Revelation 4:11

[11] "Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they existed and were created."

John 17:23

[23] I in them and you in me, that they may become perfectly one, so that the world may know that you sent me and loved them even as you loved me.

Ephesians 1:10

[10] as a plan for the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth.

Hebrews 12:1,23

[1] Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us… [23] and to the assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven, and to God, the judge of all, and to the spirits of the righteous made perfect,

1 Corinthians 12:13

[13] For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body — Jews or Greeks, slaves or free — and all were made to drink of one Spirit.

Ephesians 3:14-15

[14] For this reason I bow my knees before the Father, [15] from whom every family in heaven and on earth is named,

Romans 16:5

[5] Greet also the church in their house. Greet my beloved Epaenetus, who was the first convert to Christ in Asia.

1 Corinthians 16:19

[19] The churches of Asia send you greetings. Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord.

1 Corinthians 1:2

[2] To the church of God that is in Corinth, to those sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints together with all those who in every place call upon the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, both their Lord and ours:

2 Corinthians 1:1

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, and Timothy our brother, To the church of God that is at Corinth, with all the saints who are in the whole of Achaia:

1 Thessalonians 1:1

[1] Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy, To the church of the Thessalonians in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ: Grace to you and peace.

Acts 9:31

[31] So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria had peace and was being built up. And walking in the fear of the Lord and in the comfort of the Holy Spirit, it multiplied.

Acts 2:42

[42] And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.

Ephesians 2:19

[19] So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God,

1 Peter 3:15

[15] but in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect,

Matthew 6:33

[33] But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

7

Mobilized for Mission

The Advancement of God's Kingdom

We share the good news and pursue the advancement of God's Kingdom in our communities, our cities, and the nations.

Opening question

Have you ever visited a country with an active monarchy (if not, think of what you have seen in movies)? Describe what it was like.

Recite Matthew 6:33.

Lesson objective

This last lesson helps raise awareness of the kingdom of God. Receiving the good news is the key to entrance into God's kingdom and the means through which God brings his kingdom on earth as it is in heaven. As God has loved us, we love others by stewarding what God has given us to participate in his kingdom's advancement by fulfilling our collective and individual disciple-making mission.

"Seek not to understand that you may believe, but believe that you may understand."

Saint Augustine

The meaning of the kingdom of God

The Bible's basic meaning of "kingdom" is God's kingly rule: his reign, lordship, and sovereign governance. Basically, it is a way of ordering things. Look up the following verses and fill in the blanks.

1. Psalm 103:19. It is the *rule* of God on earth and in heaven.

2. Luke 4:43. God's kingly rule involves a saving and a redeeming activity on behalf of his people, which is why the coming of the kingdom in the New Testament is called *good news*.

3. Mark 1:15. Repent and believe in the gospel is the key to entrance into God's kingdom.

First, the present aspect. Jesus taught his disciples to pray, "...your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (Matthew 6:10). When we pray and seek God's kingdom, we also pray for his rule and reign in our lives. Jesus said, "...behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you" (Luke 17:21), speaking of himself. When you are under his lordship, and when he is in control of your life, that is God's kingdom (Romans 8:17; Ephesians 3:6).

Second, the future aspect. We pray for a day when God will return to restore all things (Acts 3:21). The new heaven and new earth will be established (Revelation 21:1), and Christ will reign in his eternal kingdom forever. As believers, we will participate in that with him forever; this is a future vision we hope for and hold onto.

The subjects of God's kingdom

4. Read Matthew 6:33. What should be our priority?

the kingdom of God and his righteousness

5. Read Matthew 6:10. What should be our prayer?

that his will be done on earth as it is in heaven

6. Read Romans 14:17. What constitutes the kingdom of God?

righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit

7. Read Matthew 5:3-12. View the characteristics of God's kingdom people and list the corresponding promises.

A. Dependent on God	*theirs is the kingdom of heaven*
B. Mournful over sin	*they shall be comforted*
C. Submissive to God's will	*they shall inherit the earth*
D. Passionate for righteousness	*they shall be satisfied*
E. Merciful / compassionate	*they shall receive mercy*
F. Authentic / unadulterated	*they shall see God*
G. Peacemakers	*they shall be called the sons of God*
H. Joyful even when persecuted	*theirs is the kingdom of heaven*

"The kingdom of God and Satan's kingdom of darkness exist side by side. Both are

advancing. Satan's work grabs the newspaper headlines and forces our attention. But God's kingdom often advances in quiet, unnoticeable ways."

Darrow Miller

There are many aspects of God's kingdom to consider and experience, but knowing about it is not enough; Jesus calls and commands us to help advance it.

How do we advance God's kingdom on earth?

8. Read John 13:34. What is the new commandment of Christ Jesus?

Love one another as he has loved us

In what ways can you show your observance of this command?

9. Read Matthew 28:18-20. What is the great commission of Christ?

make disciples of all nations, baptize them, teach them to obey

As God has loved us, we love others by stewarding what God has given us to participate in his kingdom's advancement by fulfilling our collective and individual disciple-making mission.

What hurdles or hindrances are you facing that make it challenging to observe this command?

What is the relationship between the lordship of Christ and the expansion of the kingdom of God?

ALL authority in heaven and on earth has been given to Jesus, therefore...

The kingdom of God has an "already but not yet" aspect: Jesus inaugurated it, but it has not yet come to its full glory. In this in-between time, we are invited to play a vital part in making disciples of all nations so that his kingdom may come on earth as it is in heaven.

Last exercise

Read **Colossians**.

Scripture for this lesson

Matthew 6:33

[33] But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

Psalm 103:19

[19] The LORD has established his throne in the heavens, and his kingdom rules over all.

Luke 4:43

[43] but he said to them, “I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God to the other towns as well; for I was sent for this purpose.”

Mark 1:15

[15] and saying, “The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

Matthew 6:10

[10] Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

Romans 8:17

[17] and if children, then heirs — heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him.

Ephesians 3:6

[6] This mystery is that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel.

Acts 3:21

[21] whom heaven must receive until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets long ago.

Revelation 21:1

[1] Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more.

Romans 14:17

[17] For the kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking but of righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.

Matthew 5:3-12

[3] “Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. [4] “Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted. [5] “Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth. [6] “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied. [7] “Blessed are the merciful, for they shall receive mercy. [8] “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God. [9] “Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called sons of God. [10] “Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness’ sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. [11] “Blessed are you when others revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. [12] Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you.

John 13:34

[34] A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another.

Matthew 28:18-20

[18] And Jesus came and said to them, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. [19] Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, [20] teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

Words of the faith.

above reproach

A quality where one is not only innocent of wrongdoing but any suspicion of it.

adoption

God's act of making us his children — members of his family. When we believe in Jesus and receive the Holy Spirit, we become adopted children of our heavenly Father.

adoration

An attitude of worship characterised by love and reverence towards God.

adversary

An opponent or foe; one that speaks against another, a complainant; an enemy, and specially the devil. (1 Peter 5:8)

affliction

A state of sickness, poverty; the oppression of the weak by the strong and rich; perverted justice.

alien

A foreigner; not a local.

alienated

A state of being separate or apart from something or someone, often accompanied by an awareness of the separation. Human beings are alienated from God on account of sin.

alive in the spirit

Jesus was resurrected from the dead by the Holy Spirit (1 Peter 3:18); while Jesus was physically dead, his own personal spirit, himself in Spirit form, somehow was made alive before his physical resurrection to accomplish certain purposes.

amen

A Hebrew term expressing the ideas of truth and reliability, often used in prayer and adoration; an expression of agreement.

animated

Full of life. (Galatians 5:16-17)

apostle

"One who is sent," particularly with an important message; as used in the New Testament, refers to the original disciples of Jesus.

Asceticism

The practice of being an "ascetic" or a "spiritual athlete" — training for discipline and disposition of heart to cultivate virtue and faith. Traditionally, the ascetic "exercises" of the faith include daily prayers, Bible reading, fasting, charitable giving, and church services.

assembly of the firstborn enrolled in heaven

All those whose names are written in heaven — believers of all ages, dead or alive. The Greek word for "church" simply means "called-out assembly." Romans 8:29 says that Christ is the firstborn of many brothers and sisters — another way of saying the "gathering of people in Jesus Christ." The term firstborn emphasizes that Christ is preeminent over all creation and the first of many to be resurrected and given a glorified body. (Hebrews 12:23)

assurance

The confidence or knowledge that one has come into new life with God and that with the Holy Spirit's help, one will persevere with Christ to the end life; this knowledge or confidence is based both on the promises of the Bible and the internal witness of the Spirit.

baptism

Comes from Greek words meaning to wash, immerse, submerge; it is normal Christian practice to baptize one who comes to believe in God as a sign of their repentance and new life in Christ.

Beatitudes

Blessings pronounced by Jesus Christ in the Sermon on the Mount on those whose lives exhibit particular characteristics or qualities; these contrast sharply with popular values and outlooks.

belief

Acceptance that something is true, which may lead to action and greater value (Romans 10:9-10; John 12:42-43). "Belief, "faith," and "trust" are often used to translate the same idea in the original languages of the Bible.

believer

One who has faith in God. The term came to be used specifically to refer to those who place their faith and trust in God, as he has made himself known through Jesus Christ.

bestow

To "give away;" the term has its richest significance in expressing God's abundant gift of grace and love.

Bible

Is the collection of writings that reveals God's truth. The Bible (which refers to itself as "Scripture" from the Latin word for writing) was composed by human authors who were inspired by the Holy Spirit to write down God's truth (Exodus 20:1; Daniel 9:2; 2 Timothy 3:16-17). The Bible is made up of two "Testaments" or witness statements. The Old Testament has 39 books; the New Testament has 27. It has history books, poetry, prophecy, visions, legal documents, gospels and letters. The Bible reveals the character and nature of God (Luke 24:44-47; Romans 1:1-4; Hebrews 1:1-3) and tells the story of God's plan of salvation through the good news of Jesus Chris — the Gospel.

blessed

If someone is blessed, then they have received the promised goodness of God in their lives.

born again

A scriptural term (John 3:3-8) referring to God's work of regeneration by which he imparts new spiritual life to us.

breaking of bread

Meaning either eating together or celebrating the Lord's Supper.

breathed out by God

Description of the Word of God; God's inspired words in the Bible.

catalytic

Causing a process or event to happen or increasing the rate at which it happens; setting something into motion.

Christ; Jesus Christ

From the similar-sounding Greek word "Christos," which describes the divine "Son of God," the "Anointed King," and the "Messiah" who is positioned and purposed by God to be the "Deliverer" of all people in a way that no regular person, prophet, judge, or ruler could be (2 Samuel 7:14; Psalm 2:7). In addition, the name "Jesus" is actually the historically common Hebraic "Joshua" or "Yeshua," which means "God saves" (Nehemiah 7:7; Matthew 1:21).

Christian

Those who belong to Jesus Christ; other designations in Scripture are "believers," "disciples," and "children of God." Originally a nickname, the term is only used three times in the Bible.

church

Community of all true believers for all time.

circumcised; circumcision of Christ

A practice instituted by God for his people during the time of Abraham in Genesis 17. It involves cutting off the foreskin of any male child born to Jewish parents or any slave bought by Jewish people (Genesis 17:10-14). It was a sign that someone belonged to God's people. In the apostle Paul's writings, he says that for someone to be truly one of God's people they must have an inward "circumcision of heart" by the Spirit of God.

commune with God

Refers to God's communication and presentation of himself to us, together with our proper response to him; assumes that God comes to us in love and that we respond joyfully to the beauty of his perfections and the offer of his fellowship.

confess

To admit one's sin; to agree with God. (1 John 1:9)

conviction (of sin)

To experience the loathsomeness of sin; when one becomes mindful of how much our sin dishonors God; when one becomes intensely aware of the wrath sin exposes to our souls. The Holy Spirit not only convicts people of sin, but he also brings them to repentance.

core value

A belief that is basic and more important than any other. For UCM, the 5 Core Values are: Centered on the Gospel; Called to Renewal; Rooted in Scripture; United in Christ; and Mobilized for Mission.

covenant

An unchangeable, divinely imposed legal agreement between God and humanity that specifies the conditions of the relationship.

covetousness

A strong desire to have that which belongs to another. It is considered to be a grievous offense in Scripture. (Exodus 20:17)

death in the flesh

From 1 Peter 3:18 when Christ died in his human nature.

denomination

A recognized autonomous branch of the Christian church.

disciple

Someone who learns from a teacher. To be a disciple of Jesus Christ is to learn from him and follow his teachings.

disobedience

Refusal to obey someone, especially someone in a position of authority; Scripture insists on the significance of obedience to God.

elemental spirits of the world

Refers to the gods of former pagan religions or spirits in folklore derived from earth, air, fire, and water; promoting basic worldly ideas about religion and trying to pass them off as truth. (Paul's warning to the Colossians)

eternal life

A state of being in a permanent living relationship with God through Jesus Christ.

evil; evil desire

Is used to describe beings, attitudes, or things that are opposed to God and his law.

exhortation

To encourage and to admonish.

faith

Trust or dependence on God based on the fact that we take him at his word and believe what he has said.

faithful; faithfulness

Belief that God will always do what he has said and fulfill what he has promised.

fellowship

Shared participation within a community; the word in the Greek is "koinonia," and it's most often translated into English as "sharing" or "communion."

flesh

As in the human body.

forgiveness

Freeing of a person from guilt and its consequences, including punishment; usually as an act of favor, compassion or love, with the aim of restoring a broken personal relationship.

forsake the sin

To give up; renounce; abandon sin.

Gentile

Refers to anyone who is not ethnically Jewish — that is, someone who belongs to the other "nations" of the world rather than to God's ancient people "Israel."

glory; glory of God

A translation of a Hebrew word that originally meant "heavy" or "weighty;" to give immense significance to something or someone; the word also has a sense of beauty, majesty, or perfection; God's honor.

God

The Creator and Redeemer of the world, who reveals himself in Scripture and in Jesus Christ, and who is loved, worshipped, and adored by believers. Scripture stresses the personal nature of God and his total reliability and trustworthiness. God is the Father of Jesus Christ and of all believers.

God's kingdom

Or, less frequently, "kingdom of heaven," the kingly rule of God in the lives of people and nations; it refers to the recognition of the authority of God, rather than a definite geographical area, and begins with the ministry of Jesus Christ.

God's promises

God's pledge that something will (or will not) be done or given or come to pass. These are not flippant, casual pledges such as we often make; these promises of God are rocksolid, unequivocal commitments made by God himself. Because God is faithful, the recipients of the divine promises can have full assurance that what God has pledged will indeed be realized. (Numbers 23:19)

gospel; good news

Comes from the Old English “god-spel” meaning “good story” — the equivalent of the Greek word “euangelion,” which means “good news” — the good news of God’s redemption of sinful humanity through the life, death, and resurrection of his son, Jesus Christ.

grace

God’s blessing on the undeserving; unmerited favor; God’s goodness toward those who deserve only punishment.

Great Commission

The set of final commands from Jesus to the disciples before he ascended into heaven. (Matthew 28:16-20)

heart

In Jewish thought (and later in Greek thought), the term ‘heart’ was used to mean the center of the inward life of a person, the place of deep desires. It is the place where emotions are formed and the will is held.

Heaven

The place or state of existence where God most fully makes known his presence to bless; where God most fully reveals his glory, and where angels, other heavenly creatures, and redeemed saints, all worship him.

Hell

Is the final destination or state of existence for those who reject God’s self-disclosure. (Matthew 25:31-46) It is the place of eternal punishment for the enemies of God — both Satan and his demons. (Revelation 20:10)

Holy Spirit

The spirit of God whose work it is to manifest the active presence of God in the world, and especially in the church.

holy; holiness

“Separated” or “set apart;” complete moral goodness, purity; putting aside all evil behaviour and purifying ourselves, as is fitting for a Holy God; a biblical teaching that God is separated from sin and devoted to seeking his own honor.

hostility

Unfriendliness or opposition.

idolatry

Worship or adoration of anyone or anything other than the Lord God, including other gods, images or idols, and the creation itself.

ill will

Bad feelings between people because of things that happened in the past.

impurity

The condition of being defiled in some sense; can also refer to the contaminant itself: an unwanted substance that makes something unclean.

inherit the earth

Reception of blessing for the meek in the Beatitudes; the meek receive as a gift from God everything they need, finding deep contentment and joy.

inheritance of the saints

Believers’ privilege to receive a spiritual inheritance from their heavenly Father as a result of their adoption into the family of God through faith.

intercession

Asking God for something on behalf of someone else.

Jew

God’s ancient people “Israel;” designation for descendants of the people from the kingdom of Judah and also for adherents to their religion from other nations.

judgment

God’s final judgment of all people has been entrusted to Jesus Christ who, at his return, will reward the righteous and punish the unrighteous. Judgment will be on the active response to God’s revelation and faith in Jesus Christ. Believers need not fear the last judgment but live godly lives in anticipation of it. (John 5:24)

likeness

Referring to something that is similar but not identical to the thing it represents, such as man’s being made after God’s “likeness.” (Genesis 1:26)

Lord

A Greek translation of “kyrios” in the New Testament that is usually, but not always, used to refer to Christ. In the Greek translation of the Old Testament, it’s used to translate the Hebrew “YHWH,” the personal name of God.

Lord's Supper

One of the two sacred elements that Jesus instituted his church to observe as a sign of the new life and continuing fellowship in Christ.

making wise the simple

From Psalm 19:7, an introduction of the law of the Lord — meaning Scripture — as God's perfect revelation of himself and his will; it imparts "wisdom to the humble, those who exercise a childlike submission to it."

meekness

An attitude of humble, submissive and expectant trust in God, and a loving, patient, and gentle attitude towards others.

members in the household of God

Members of God's family.

minister (or to minister)

One who takes part in ministry, the service of God; in relation to Christ, every church has a ministry of serving the Lord by proclaiming God's Word in words and deeds.

new heaven and new earth

A way of referring to the new creation that God will culminate in the future. The theme of the restoration and re-creation of the world is a central aspect of the Christian hope.

not-yet believer

Someone who has yet to have faith in God; also "Pre-believer."

omnipotence

The quality of having unlimited power; the teaching that God is able to do all his holy will.

omnipresence

The property of being present anywhere and everywhere; the teaching that God does not have size or spatial dimensions and is present at every point of space with his whole beng, yet God acts differently in different places.

omniscience

The capacity to know everything; the teaching that God fully knows himself and all things actual and possible in one simple and eternal act.

Pastor

A term used interchangeably with "elder," or "overseer" and "bishop" to refer to the main governing office of a local church in the New Testament. Translating the Greek "poimen," the term identifies the shepherding task with the office of the elder.

Pentecost

A Jewish feast during which the Holy Spirit was poured out in fullness and power on the disciples.

perseverance (of the saints)

The doctrine that all those who are truly "born again" will be kept by God's power and will persevere (continue in the face of difficulty) as Christians until the end of the their lives, and that only those who persevere until the end have been truly "born again."

physical death

Termination of life brought about by the entrance of sin in the world. For the Christian, death brings one into the presence of God because of Christ's payment of the penalty of sins.

prayer

A communicative relationship with God.

precepts

A commandment, an authoritative rule for action.

preeminence

Superiority, especially in noble or excellent qualities.

profess

To make an open declaration of one's belief, action, etc.; to avow or acknowledge; to confess publicly; to own or admit freely.

prophesy

To prophesy (verb) is simply to pronounce prophecy. Prophecy (noun), at its most fundamental meaning, is "a message from God." Hence, to prophesy is to declare a message from God.

rebellion

State of revolt against established divine or human authority.

redeem / redemption

Buying back or releasing an object or person. In Scripture, it refers to God's ransoming of believers through the death of Jesus Christ upon the cross and to all the benefits that this brings.

repentance

A heartfelt sorrow for sin, a renouncing of it, and a sincere commitment to forsake it and walk in obedience to Christ.

reproof

Rebuke (with a connotation of deliberateness).

resentment

Anger and the like because of forced acceptance of something one does not like.

righteousness

A state of being right or set apart before God; a following of God's standards.

Sabbath

From the word Shabbat that essentially means "a day of rest." God commanded a day of rest because he wants us to trust him; observing Sabbath helps keep believers from idolatry and its implications.

sacrifice

Christ's death on the cross viewed from the standpoint that he paid the penalty that people deserved.

saints

People of God, especially in relation to their being set apart from the world to serve him.

salvation

Transformation of a person's individual nature and relationship with God as a result of repentance and faith in the atoning death of Jesus Christ on the cross. All humanity stands in need of salvation, which is only possible through faith in Jesus Christ.

sanctification

A progressive work of God in believers that makes believers increasingly more free from sin and Christlike in all of life.

Scripture

The writings of the Old and New Testaments that have historically been recognized as God's words in written form; another term for the Bible.

Scythian

Those who lived along the Black Sea and Caspian Sea. In the first century, Scythians were considered the worst of barbarians by the Greeks. (Colossians 3:11) The writer, Paul, will soon give spiritual instructions for Christian slaves at the end of this particular chapter.

Sermon on the Mount

A collection of Jesus Christ's teaching on the theme of what it entails to be a disciple/follower/learner of his.

sexual immorality; sexual sin

Sexual behaviour which is contrary to God's law; any transgression of the limits that God has set for the enjoyment of sex. Such sins are often life-dominating, but may be broken through the power and grace of Jesus Christ.

sin

Is thought, speech or action that goes against and breaks God's law. It is an attitude of rebellion against God, seeking to rule one's own life and ignoring God's authority over us. (The Bible also uses words such as iniquity, transgressions, debts and wickedness for behaviour that goes against God's will.)

sin management

Concern mostly or only with how to deal with sin — with wrongdoing or wrongbeing and its effects.

slave

A person who is held in bondage to another; one who is wholly subject to the will of another.

sovereignty

God's complete control over all things in nature and the affairs of humanity past, present, and future.

sphere of influence

Contains all that we are able to affect but not directly control, including the actions of some people and systems in which one operates.

spiritual death

Eternal separation from God for eternity in Hell.

spiritual gifts

Any ability that is empowered by the Holy Spirit and used in any ministry of the church; given for the common good and used for "building up" the church.

spiritual opposition

Powers and forces that oppose the knowledge of God. (Ephesians 6:12)

spiritual progress

Being free from everything that usurps the place of God; whenever God's work removes something from the believer other than God, we have spiritual progress. (Luke 14)

steadfast

To be firm; secure; enduring.

stewardship

Obligation of Christians in managing and utilizing intelligently the gifts that God has given.

stir up

To inspire Christians to be confident, courageous, and uplifted in living out their faith. (Hebrews 10:24)

subscribe to God

Or "submit ourselves to God" means acknowledgement of his Lordship in life. Believers give up selfish desires, hopes, and wants and choose to follow Jesus wherever he leads by the help of the Holy Spirit.

suffering

Experience of pain or distress, both physical and emotional. Scripture is thoroughly realistic about the place of suffering in the world and in the lives of believers. To become a Christian is not to escape from suffering, but to be able to bear it with dignity and hope.

superintended

To be in charge of something.

supplication

A request; a prayer of supplication is asking God for something. Unlike the prayer of petition, which is praying on behalf of others, the prayer of supplication is generally a request for the person praying.

temptation

An enticement to sin or an invitation to disobey God.

testimony

A declaration or affirmation made for the purpose of establishing or proving some fact; a public profession of one's faith journey and relationship with God.

testing

God allows his people to pass through certain experiences to prove to them that their faith in him is genuine. Believers sometimes doubt God and test him, to see if he is true to his word, but this is forbidden in Scripture. (Matthew 4:5-7)

The Day

Day of Jesus' return. The period of judgment and restoration at the end of time, as God punishes the wicked and establishes the new creation.

transgression

Sin; any violation of a law or command.

trespasses

To pass beyond a limit or boundary; to enter unlawfully upon the land of another; to go too far; to commit any offense, any violation of a known rule of duty; sin.

trial

Trials (and tribulations) are more than hardship in the Christian faith; a testing of faith where one's devotion to Christ can grow as a result of suffering.

Trinity

God eternally exists as three persons, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit; each person is fully God, and there is one God.

unbeliever

Those who are unwilling to believe and trust in God, especially as he has made himself known in and through Jesus Christ.

universal church

The visible church; a group of people who come together each Sunday to worship as a Church, profess faith in Christ, and live as a community of believers.

wages of sin

The payment for our sin, and the payment is death. (Romans 6:23)

washing of regeneration

The Greek word for “washing” in Titus 3:5 describes the act of cleansing something all over thoroughly. Regeneration means taking an already existing thing and making it new again or starting over. In literal terms, it means “birth again.”

will

An attribute of God whereby he approves and determines to bring about every action necessary for the existence and activity of himself and all creation.

wisdom

An attribute of God whereby he always chooses the best goals and the best means to those goals.

Word of God

Refers to the Son of God; the decrees of God; God’s word of personal address; God’s words spoken through human lips; God’s words in written form, the Bible.

worldview

The way a person sees and understands the world, especially regarding issues such as politics, philosophy, and religion.

worship

Reverence and devotion; the attributing of glory and honor; biblical worship is directed toward God alone.

wrath

An attribute of God whereby God intensely hates all sin. (Colossians 3:5-10)

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